

Recovery roadmap for overcoming friendship trauma and rebuilding self-trust after abuse — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

DOCUMENT THE HARM

- ☐ **Document the Harm:** Create a written Abuse Pattern Map document titled 'What Actually Happened' so you have a concrete record that exists outside your own head.
- ☐ **Document the Harm:** Stop using vague words like 'toxic' or 'complicated' to describe what happened, because vague language keeps your brain stuck in confusion about whether it was really that bad.
- ☐ **Document the Harm:** Write out a specific timeline with dates and events rather than just replaying memories in your head, because writing forces your brain to distinguish facts from feelings.
- ☐ **Document the Harm:** Record exact quotes and specific behaviors instead of general summaries like 'she criticized me,' because precision breaks the spell of the vague narrative your abuser conditioned you to accept.

IDENTIFY THE PATTERNS

- ☐ **Identify the Patterns:** Identify and document every instance of manipulation and covert control, including moments she made you feel like you needed her permission or kept you off-balance with past 'mistakes.'
- ☐ **Identify the Patterns:** Identify and document every instance of social sabotage, including times she turned mutual friends against you or positioned herself as the authority on who you really are.
- ☐ **Identify the Patterns:** Identify and document every instance of boundary violation, including times she showed up uninvited, pushed you to share information you weren't comfortable with, or used your vulnerabilities against you.
- ☐ **Identify the Patterns:** Identify and document every instance of emotional dismissal, including times she turned conversations about your struggles into stories about herself or reframed her harmful behavior as 'just being honest.'

END THE CONFUSION

- ☐ **End the Confusion:** Stop reconciling her abusive behavior with the 'good' version of her from the first year, because the pattern of harmful behavior is what defines the friendship, not the disguise she performed initially.
 - ☐ **End the Confusion:** Stop overriding your nervous system's signals that 'something is wrong' with explanations like 'she's stressed' or 'I'm being sensitive,' because your body knew what was happening even when your prefrontal cortex refused to accept it.
 - ☐ **End the Confusion:** Write down the moment you first noticed something felt wrong and track how you explained it away over time, because seeing your own gaslighting documented will help you trust your own judgment again.
 - ☐ **End the Confusion:** Name what you experienced as abuse rather than a 'complicated friendship' to end the internal debate that's keeping you stuck, because your own gaslighting about whether it was 'really that bad' is still doing her work for her.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.